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AI Claims Authority: How Source and Corrective Strategy Shape Perceived Credibility in Combating Misinformation

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ABSTRACT

AI has been increasingly deployed to combat misinformation, yet its credibility remains contested, partly due to overlooking the factor of corrective strategies. This study addresses this gap by conducting a 3 (source: human vs. AI vs. human-AI hybrid) × 2 (corrective strategy: evidence-based vs. authority-based) × 2 (topic: social vs. scientific) mixed-design experiment. Results showed that AI adopting authority-based strategies was associated with decreased credibility, while stronger machine heuristic beliefs and authoritarian personality mitigated this negative effect for AI and hybrid sources. Findings highlight the confounding role of corrective strategies in AI credibility scholarship, offering implications for automated misinformation correction.

Introduction

Listed as a premier global risk nowadays (World Economic Forum, 2025), misinformation often spreads more rapidly than truth, disturbing almost every human endeavor (Vosoughi et al., 2018). As human verification struggles to keep pace with the scale and speed of misinformation on digital media (Vosoughi et al., 2018), artificial intelligence (AI) has been applied to detect and refute falsehoods in real time (Johnson, 2024). Despite its rapid adoption, evidence regarding AI's credibility in combating misinformation remains mixed, with findings ranging from positive to neutral or negative (J. Lee & Bissell, 2024; Moon & Kahlor, 2025).

Existing literature has predominantly focused on the mere presence of an “AI label,” while overlooking how corrective messages are communicated. Behind these inconsistent findings, a critical confounder lies in the specific corrective strategy. Broadly, correction messages tend to rely on either evidence-based (logos) or authority-based strategies (ethos) (Palm & Tims, 2025; Xiao & Burke, 2024). Evidence-based strategies focus on tracing data sources and providing complex logical explanations. They are professionalized but may impose high cognitive loads, leading to mixed empirical effectiveness (Chan & Albarracín, 2023; Walter et al., 2020). Conversely, authority-based strategies offer a direct verdict with an unquestionable tone, bare verdict badges, or commanding language. These stylistic cues serve as powerful mental shortcuts that trigger the authority heuristic, allowing sources to project credibility even without engaging in systematic argumentation (Sundar, 2008; Xue et al., 2024). This approach has been widely adopted in practice (Lu & Shen, 2023; Radkani

et al., 2024), aligning with the view that corrective messages should be simpler and easier to comprehend than the original misinformation (Lewandowsky et al., 2012).

While human checkers can seamlessly pivot between these strategies, this stylistic performance of authority creates a profound theoretical tension when applied to AI sources. According to the machine heuristic (Sundar, 2008), audiences generally expect AI to be an objective, data-driven processor, a role that naturally aligns with the evidence-based strategy. In contrast, authority-based strategies which rely on commanding tones and definitive verdicts traditionally derive their persuasive power from human institutional legitimacy and socio-political standing (Johnson, 2024). When an AI employs an authority-based strategy, it assumes a sociopolitical privilege it inherently lacks. Drawing on the expectancy violation theory (EVT, Burgoon, 2015), we propose that this mismatch between the AI identity and the authoritative communication style may trigger negative expectancy violations, potentially penalizing the AI's perceived credibility.

To address this issue, we conducted a 3 (source: human vs. AI vs. human-AI hybrid) $\times 2$ (corrective strategy: evidence-based vs. authority-based) $\times 2$ (topic: social vs. scientific) online factorial experiment. Crucially, we also examined whether individual characteristics, especially machine heuristic beliefs and authoritarian personality, can moderate these expectancy violation effects. This study contributes to emerging work on AI authorship and offers practical implications for designing effective misinformation interventions in the post-truth era.

Literature Review

AI Source in Corrective Messages

A substantial body of literature warns of potential null or negative effects regarding AI-labeled fact-checking (Kim & Lee, 2025; Wang & Ophir, 2026), with three main explanatory mechanisms. First, the classic computers are social actors (CASA) paradigm suggests people react to machines as they do to humans, indicating similar credibility between humans and AI (Reeves & Nass, 1996). Second, opponents of AI fact-checking suggest audiences may exhibit deep-seated skepticism toward AI when moral judgment or contextual understanding is required (Wang & Huang, 2024). Finally, due to AI's popularity and extensive media coverage, some critics argue that people's perceived novelty and blind AI trust have diminished (Xue et al., 2024). These findings and views suggest a negative effect of AI source on credibility.

In contrast, some studies have emerged, suggesting that AI labels may enhance credibility by reducing perceived bias and motivated reasoning (Moon & Kahlor, 2025), thereby lowering ideological and intergroup resistance to fact-checking. This pattern has been observed outside America, such as in China and Spain (Chen et al., 2025; Wojcieszak et al., 2021). These studies are mostly based on the concept of machine heuristic in Sundar's (2008) Modality-Agency-Interactivity-Navigability (MAIN) model, suggesting that people have some stereotypes about AI, including objective, neutral, accurate, and free from ideological bias. Hence, people may unconsciously assume that AI will provide accurate, unbiased information, positioning it as a neutral source with higher credibility (Moon & Kahlor, 2025). Overall, there is no clear consensus on whether AI sources are more or less credible than humans when correcting misinformation.

Furthermore, human-machine collaboration has become increasingly prevalent. Nowadays, AI is no longer just a tool but functions as a coauthor within a human-in-the-loop framework under human oversight (Liu & Wei, 2018). Theoretically, the potential of this hybrid model is grounded in the principle of human-AI complementarity, which posits that the combined performance of human and machine agents can exceed that of either agent acting alone (Jarrahi, 2018). However, the realization of this complementarity is context-dependent. Research indicates that the synergy of human-AI collaboration varies significantly across different task categories. The hybrid agent is believed to play a positive role in sales and medical consultations (Göndöcs et al., 2025), but it is less clear in correcting misinformation.

One conjecture is that while machines excel at summarizing information and retrieving data, humans contribute through higher-order interpretation and analytical judgment (Wang & Huang, 2024), indicating a potential credibility improvement (Waddell, 2019). However, other studies indicate that hybrids are perceived as equal to single sources (Tandoc et al., 2020; Wölker & Powell, 2021) or even less credible than humans alone (Chen et al., 2025). Based on the mixed findings, we ask:

RQ1: In the context of correcting misinformation, will human, AI, and human-AI hybrid sources be perceived with different levels of credibility?

Evidence-Based and Authority-Based Strategies for Misinformation Correction

Communication scholarship has long examined diverse persuasion strategies to influence public belief. While classifications vary, a fundamental distinction, traceable to Aristotelian rhetoric (logos vs. ethos), exists between appealing to reason through data and appealing to credibility through source status (Cialdini, 2009; Xiao & Burke, 2024). To explicate the cognitive mechanisms underlying these approaches, we draw on the heuristic-systematic model (HSM) of information processing (Chaiken, 1987). HSM posits that individuals process information via two concurrent modes: systematic processing, which involves comprehensive analytic effort, and heuristic processing, which relies on simple decision rules or cues. Based on this framework, we conceptualize two distinct corrective strategies: evidence-based strategies, targeting systematic processing, and authority-based strategies, targeting heuristic processing.

The evidence-based strategy relies on the logical provision of facts, data, and falsifiable proof (logos). It operates on the premise of systematic processing, inviting audiences to scrutinize message content and engage in cognitive elaboration. This approach is currently the gold standard in professional fact-checking. Fact-checkers are required to trace evidence from multiple perspectives to cross-verify facts and make all analytical processes transparent to the public, allowing readers to replicate the conclusions (Graves & Amazeen, 2019). However, empirical evidence is mixed. While systematic processing can lead to stable misperception change, it demands high cognitive resources (Tandoc et al., 2024). Consequently, detailed refutations may overwhelm audiences or blur memory of the verdict, or even trigger backfire effects (Chan & Albarracín, 2023). Thus, while professionalized, the evidence-based strategy is not always effective due to the public's cognitive constraints (Tandoc et al., 2024).

In contrast, the authority-based strategy operates on the mechanism of heuristic processing (ethos). Instead of inviting the audience to scrutinize data, this strategy asks them to trust the judgment of a source perceived as legitimate or powerful (Cialdini, 2009), applying the “authority heuristic” to reach a quick conclusion (Sundar, 2008; Xue et al., 2024).

In the context of digital media, the authority heuristic is often operationalized as a stylistic choice, manifesting through definitive tones, authoritative labels, or bare verdict badges. It aligns with Sundar’s (2008) MAIN Model, which posits that people rely heavily on surface cues, treating these stylistic features as powerful mental shortcuts. For instance, an unfamiliar website can increase its credibility simply by using an authoritative-looking logo, which signals “pedigree” and believability despite its poor content quality (Sundar, 2008, p. 84). It indicates that authority-based strategies are not exclusive to actors with actual social authority but can also be employed even by anonymous sources (Van Der Meer & Jin, 2020).

In conclusion, the evidence-based strategy operates at the level of substantive message content. It derives persuasive force from the transparent provision of verifiable facts, data sources, and reasoning chains, thereby inviting systematic scrutiny and cognitive elaboration. In contrast, authority-based correction operates at the level of surface presentation, demanding heuristic deference while actively bypassing external proof. Because these two strategies activate different dimensions of persuasion, substantive argumentation versus heuristic cues, they are conceptually independent rather than hierarchically nested.

However, it remains theoretically ambiguous which strategy is more credible. One stream of research suggests that reducing linguistic complexity (Walter et al., 2020) and adopting a decisive, formal stance (Yu et al., 2022) can enhance credibility by signaling certainty, supporting authority-based strategies. Lewandowsky et al. (2012) also argue that “less is more,” recommending simple rebuttals over detailed explanations. However, contradictory evidence also exists (Pornpitakpan & Francis, 2000; Xiao & Burke, 2024), implying that people might dynamically weigh the cognitive cost of processing evidence against the risk of blindly trusting authority cues. Hence, we ask:

RQ2: Between evidence-based and authority-based strategies, which corrective approach is more credible?

The distinction between evidence-based and authority-based strategies offers a new lens to resolve the inconsistent findings regarding AI’s credibility in fact-checking. We argue that this inconsistency may stem from the variation in corrective strategies employed in prior experiments. Some studies, simulating professional fact-checking organizations, tended to employ evidence-based strategies for AI sources (Chae & Tewksbury, 2024; Y. Sun, 2025). In such contexts, the AI agent provided detailed reasoning, data retrieval, and transparency, which may mask the potential aversion toward the AI source. Conversely, in some other scholarship, AI is increasingly portrayed as employing authority-based strategies without extensive argumentation (Kim & Lee, 2025; Moon & Kahlor, 2025; Wang & Ophir, 2026). In these scenarios, the AI demands epistemic deference to its calculation rather than inviting verification.

Different correction strategies may help explain differences in the assessment of AI’s credibility. According to EVT, communication outcomes depend on whether a source’s behavior aligns with the audience’s prescriptive expectations (Burgoon, 2015). When

expectations are violated negatively, credibility suffers. In particular, once AI deviates from traits inherent in machine heuristics, including objective, fair, and accurate expectations, people will experience negative expectation violations, leading to negative assessments of AI's credibility (e.g., Chen et al., 2025; Tandoc et al., 2020). Simply a forceful "true or false" conclusion label can significantly lower the perceived credibility of AI fact-checking (Xue et al., 2024). Hence, corrective messages with an authority-based strategy emphasize irrefutability, aiming to directly inform readers of the truth rather than presenting objective and transparent evidence. Therefore, we propose that an interaction effect may exist.

H1: An interaction effect exists between source and corrective strategy. Specifically, with an authority-based strategy, an AI source (vs. a human source) will be less credible in a corrective message.

Individual Differences: Machine Heuristic Belief and Authoritarian Personality

People hold different views about sources and communication strategies. For AI sources, the key individual characteristic is machine heuristic belief (Sundar & Kim, 2019), which indicates that those who view AI as more objective, accurate, and reliable generally evaluate AI-generated content more positively (E.-J. Lee, 2024; Wang & Ophir, 2026). Thus, we hypothesize:

H2: Machine heuristic beliefs moderate the effect of source on perceived credibility, where AI sources are more credible for those with higher levels of machine heuristic beliefs.

However, while high machine heuristic beliefs generally enhance trust, EVT suggests a more nuanced interaction when specific communicative strategies are employed. Machine heuristics do not merely foster unconditional trust; rather, they function as prescriptive expectations. Specifically, individuals with high levels of machine heuristic beliefs strongly expect AI to function as a neutral tool through transparent data and logic (E.-J. Lee, 2024). Hence, when AI deviates from these normative machine-like expectations, it triggers a severe negative expectancy violation. For instance, people evaluate AI more negatively when it exhibits unexpected human-like traits, such as displaying creative performances, writing with subjective bias, or producing emotional news (E.-J. Lee, 2024; Tandoc et al., 2020). Applying this logic to the present study, an authority-based strategy, which delivers opaque, definitive verdicts without verifiable evidence, may also contradict the expected characteristics of a neutral, data-driven machine.

Crucially, the strength of the machine heuristic dictates the intensity of the expectation (E.-J. Lee, 2024). For users who deeply believe in the machine's objective traits, encountering an opaque AI arbiter constitutes a severe expectancy violation, theoretically leading to a harsh credibility decrease. Conversely, users with low machine heuristic beliefs hold weaker expectations for "machine-like" traits and are thus less sensitive to this strategic deviation. Therefore, based on EVT reasoning, the credibility decline associated with AI's use of an authority-based strategy should be more pronounced among those holding stronger machine heuristic beliefs. Hence, we hypothesize:

H3: There is a three-way interaction between machine heuristic belief, source, and corrective strategy, where those with higher levels of machine heuristic beliefs tend to perceive corrections from AI with an authority-based strategy as less credible.

As the MAIN model notes, the authority heuristic is particularly powerful for individuals who are socially conditioned to revere authority figures (Sundar, 2008). This reflects congruence theory, which suggests that persuasion is most effective when the strategy of a message aligns with the recipient's underlying personality (Palm & Tims, 2025). Therefore, we focus on the construct of *authoritarian personality*, which is characterized by people's adherence to social rules, conventionalism, and submission to established authority (Altemeyer, 1981).

Evidence suggests that an authoritarian personality influences people's information processing. Individuals high in authoritarianism exhibit a strong need for epistemic closure (Federico et al., 2016) and prefer heuristic processing over systematic thinking (Kemmelmeyer, 2010). Consequently, for those with a stronger authoritarian personality, the authority-based strategy aligns perfectly with their cognitive disposition. They prefer these decisive, judgmental shortcuts over navigating complex, systematic scientific evidence.

H4: An individual's authoritarian personality moderates the effect of the corrective strategy on perceived credibility, as the authority-based strategy is more credible for those with higher levels of authoritarian personality.

Furthermore, this dynamic becomes theoretically complex when the authority-based strategy is deployed by machines. As proposed in H1, AI's authority-based strategy may trigger negative expectancy violations and reduce credibility. Yet, for highly authoritarian individuals, this EVT might be buffered because machines are stereotypically perceived as strictly rule-bound and accurate (Sundar, 2008). An authoritative AI perfectly feeds their need for epistemic closure. For these individuals, the AI is not violating an objective and data-driven expectation; rather, it is enforcing rules. Consequently, the credibility drop caused by the AI's authority-based strategy might be weaker among high-authoritarian individuals compared to low-authoritarian individuals. Given the limited direct evidence, we ask the following exploratory question:

RQ3: Is there a three-way interaction among authoritarian personality, source, and corrective strategy?

Contextualizing Misinformation Across Topics in China

This study situates its empirical investigation in China to test the aforementioned relationships. While political rumors dominate Western fact-checking literature (Graves & Amazeen, 2019), in the Chinese state-led media system, domestic political misinformation rarely circulates widely enough to necessitate public fact-checking. This is partly because political information is tightly regulated, limiting the space for misinformation and post-hoc fact-checking. Instead, the most prevalent corrections are actually health/science

rumors and everyday social affairs (L. Sun, 2025). Focusing on these nonpolitical topics allows us to examine the commercialized dimension of media, where misinformation is driven by traffic-seeking sensationalism or unintentional misinterpretation rather than partisan bias. Accordingly, we selected social affairs (e.g., public incidents, accidents) and science as the two focal correction topics for comparison. This design allows us to probe the robustness of our theoretical model across different misinformation domains, thereby strengthening the external validity.

The Chinese context also provides a distinct sociopolitical environment for examining AI-based corrective communication. Prior research suggests that institutional authority and hierarchical order tend to enjoy relatively higher baseline legitimacy in China (Zhai, 2017). At the same time, state-led technological development fosters comparatively high levels of public techno-optimism and acceptance of AI (Wang, 2025). Examining our theoretical model in this setting offers a valuable opportunity to observe how expectancy alignment and violation mechanisms operate in a non-Western context, where both institutional authority and AI technologies are highly salient in everyday information environments. Theoretically, people process AI sources differently across different topics (Wölker & Powell, 2021). Social affairs typically require first-hand, on-the-ground investigation, such as interviewing witnesses, which AI is not perceived to perform effectively (Wang & Huang, 2024). In contrast, scientific correction relies primarily on the retrieval and synthesis of existing expert consensus, well aligned with the data-processing capabilities and machine heuristic beliefs. Consequently, we ask:

RQ4: Are there significant differences between misinformation correction regarding social affairs and that regarding science?

Method

Sample

A priori power analysis using G*Power 3.1 (Faul et al., 2009) was conducted, adopting an effect size of $d = .19$ based on a meta-analysis on information correction (Chan & Albarracín, 2023). The analysis indicated that a sample size of 271 was the minimum required to achieve 80% power.

Accordingly, 312 participants were recruited from *WenJuanXing* (www.wjx.cn), China's largest online survey platform, which holds over six million registered members from a multitude of demographic backgrounds. The sample comprised 140 men (44.87%) and 172 women (55.13%), with an average age of 32.09 years. Most participants were married (77.56%) and held a bachelor's degree (81.73%). The median monthly personal income was between 8,001 and 10,000 Chinese Yuan (1 USD is approximately 7 CNY).

Experimental Design and Procedure

With approval from the internal review board of Shanghai Jiao Tong University (No.: H20240469I), we conducted a 3 (source: human vs. AI vs. human-AI hybrid, between-

subjects) $\times$ 2 (corrective strategy: evidence-based vs. authority-based, between-subjects) $\times$ 2 (topic: social vs. scientific, within-group) online mixed-design survey experiment.

Participants were randomly assigned to one of six between-subjects conditions and read information on scientific and social affairs topics presented in a randomized order. After reading the misinformation for each topic, participants reported their perceived veracity of the story, read the corrective messages and filled out the questionnaire. Participants were debriefed and thanked after completing all the questions.

Stimuli

The stimuli for each topic consisted of a piece of false news and a corresponding corrective message. The scientific misinformation falsely claimed that drinking alcohol before bed aids sleep. Correction with the evidence-based strategy refuted the claim by listing academic articles and publicly available scientific guidelines. In contrast, the authority-based strategy simply emphasized that drinking alcohol before bed does not aid sleep. Both articles were similar in length, each approximately 300 Chinese characters.

Participants were shown the author's information at the beginning and end of the articles, which included the AI tool "Truth Probe," a human journalist from *Chutian Metropolis Daily*, and a human journalist from *Chutian Metropolis Daily* using the AI tool "Truth Probe." "Truth Probe" is a fictional AI tool created for this experiment to minimize participants' preexisting attitudes toward specific commercial AI products, which may introduce uncontrolled variance stemming from brand trust and platform-specific techno-skepticism. This design follows prior experimental practice in which fictional technologies are used to establish a neutral baseline for isolating source effects (Kim & Lee, 2025).

Chutian Metropolis Daily is a commercial newspaper based in Hubei Province of China. It was selected as the stimulus because its credibility is moderate compared to Chinese state media and grassroots media (Li & Zhang, 2018). Therefore, *Chutian Metropolis Daily* was deemed appropriate as experimental material for correcting false news.

Similarly, misinformation in the social affairs topic described a recent tragic car accident in Fujian and included vivid images. In response, the corrective article in the evidence condition used reverse image searches and referenced publicly available online information, while the authority-based strategy declared the original claim a rumor in an unquestionable tone. To manipulate the source, participants were randomly assigned to one of the following conditions: the AI tool "Truth Probe," a human journalist from *Haixia Metropolis Daily*, or a human journalist from *Haixia Metropolis Daily* using the AI tool "Truth Probe."

Like *Chutian Metropolis Daily*, *Haixia Metropolis Daily* is also a commercial newspaper in Fujian Province of China. Apart from the text and source, other details, such as the number of likes, views, and the time of posting, were concealed.

Manipulation Check

Participants who failed to correctly identify the message source and the conclusion in the recall question were excluded from further data analysis. Participants rated to the extent to which they felt the corrective message was well supported by evidence on a seven-point Likert scale. T-tests confirmed that the manipulation was successful, that evidence-based strategy ($M_{soc} = 5.60$, $SD = 1.21$; $M_{sci} = 5.54$, $SD = 1.00$) received higher scores than the

authority-based strategy ($M_{soc} = 5.27$, $SD = 1.27$; $M_{sci} = 5.23$, $SD = 1.27$), $t_{soc} = 2.45$, $p = .015$; $t_{sci} = 2.49$, $p = .013$.

Measures

All measurements were performed using a 7-point Likert scale, ranging from 1 (*completely disagree*) to 7 (*completely agree*), except the scale for authoritarian personality.

Perceived credibility was measured following previous studies (Chen et al., 2025; Meyer, 1988), as the extent to which the source is “fair/objective,” “unbiased/neutral,” “complete,” “trustworthy,” “professional,” “accurate,” and “generally credible” ($M_{soc} = 5.53$, $SD = 0.85$, Cronbach’s $\alpha = .86$, McDonald’s $\omega = .88$; $M_{sci} = 5.41$, $SD = 0.76$, Cronbach’s $\alpha = .84$, McDonald’s $\omega = .86$).

Machine heuristic beliefs were assessed using five adapted items (Sundar & Kim, 2019): “Machines excel at judging a statement’s truth or falsehood, therefore they are reliable,” “Machines’ judgments are more accurate than humans,” “Machines are neutral, so they do not distort the facts,” “Machines’ results are more objective than humans,” and “Machines have high accuracy; therefore, they are better at judging the truth or falsehood” ($M = 5.16$, $SD = 0.97$, Cronbach’s $\alpha = .85$, McDonald’s $\omega = .86$).

Authoritarian personality. Following measures adapted from the American National Election Study and previous research (Bizumic & Duckitt, 2018), respondents indicated which of two qualities was more important for a 12-year-old child across four pairs: obedience vs. self-reliance; good manners vs. curiosity; independence vs. respect for elders, and being considerate or well behaved. Choosing the authoritarian option was coded as one score, “equally important” as zero, and the nonauthoritarian option as one negative score. Scores were summed to form an index ranging from -4 to 4 ($M = -0.32$, $SD = 1.52$, Cronbach’s $\alpha = .60$, McDonald’s $\omega = .61$). Consistent with prior research, the internal consistency of this scale is modest, typically with Cronbach’s α ranging from .58 to .63 (Bizumic & Duckitt, 2018). However, it is also considered acceptable (Engelhardt et al., 2023), especially because the measure avoids political leaning items and suits the contexts where explicit political self-report may be sensitive (Engelhardt et al., 2023).

Control variables. *Initial trust in the misinformation* was measured using a single seven-point item: “After reading the above information, to what extent do you believe it is true?” ($M_{sci} = 3.82$, $SD = 1.48$; $M_{soc} = 3.63$, $SD = 1.31$). The order of stimulus presentation was also incorporated as a control variable.

Results

OLS regressions were conducted to test our RQs and hypotheses, where the AI source and evidence-based strategy were treated as the reference category. For RQ1 and RQ2, source type showed no significant main effect, indicating similar perceived credibility across human, AI, and hybrid sources. Authority-based strategy led to a decrease in credibility when correcting social affairs misinformation ($B = -3.68$, $SE = 0.96$, $p < .001$), whereas no strategy effect appeared in scientific messages ($B = 0.77$, $SE = 0.76$, $p = .312$) (see Table 1).

H1 and H2 propose that the AI source in an authority-based message caused lower credibility, and one’s machine heuristic beliefs amplify the effect of AI source on credibility. In social affairs correction, authority-based strategy was more credible

Table 1. Regression results on perceived credibility ($N = 312$).

	Social	Scientific
Corrective strategy = authority-based	−3.68*** (0.96)	−0.79 (0.79)
Source = human	−0.40 (0.92)	0.49 (0.67)
Source = hybrid	−1.46 (0.97)	0.42 (0.85)
Authoritarian personality	0.05 (0.08)	−0.02 (0.06)
Machine heuristic belief	0.19 (0.12)	0.41*** (0.09)
Preexisting trust	0.08* (0.03)	−0.04 (0.03)
Presentation order	−0.06 (0.09)	−0.08 (0.08)
Authority-based strategy × human	4.45*** (1.22)	2.05* (1.03)
Authority-based strategy × hybrid	4.18** (1.35)	1.94 (1.18)
Authority-based strategy × authoritarian personality	−0.10 (0.10)	−0.04 (0.09)
Human × authoritarian personality	−0.01 (0.11)	0.05 (0.09)
Human × authoritarian personality	−0.09 (0.10)	−0.08 (0.09)
Authority-based strategy × machine heuristic belief	0.65*** (0.18)	0.16 (0.15)
Human × machine heuristic belief	0.07 (0.17)	−0.08 (0.13)
Hybrid × machine heuristic belief	0.26 (0.18)	−0.05 (0.16)
Authority-based strategy × Human × authoritarian personality	−0.04 (0.15)	0.16 (0.13)
Authority-based strategy × hybrid × authoritarian personality	0.21 (0.14)	0.28* (0.13)
Authority-based strategy × Human × machine heuristic belief	−0.79*** (0.23)	−0.41* (0.19)
Authority-based strategy × hybrid × machine heuristic belief	−0.75** (0.25)	−0.44* (0.22)
R ²	0.24	0.28

* $p < .05$. ** $p < .01$. *** $p < .001$. Unstandardized coefficients and standard error.

when delivered by a human ($B = 4.45$, $SE = 1.22$, $p < .001$) or hybrid source ($B = 4.18$, $SE = 1.35$, $p = .002$), as [Figure 1](#) illustrates. Similarly, in scientific correction, AI-authored authority messages were less credible ($B = 2.05$, $SE = 1.02$, $p = .047$), but the interaction effect between hybrid source and strategy was non-significant ($B = 1.94$, $SE = 1.18$, $p = .10$). Machine heuristic beliefs did not moderate any source effects. Thus, H1 was supported while H2 was rejected.

H3 predicts that machine heuristic beliefs would worsen the credibility of AI under authority-based strategy due to stronger negative expectancy violation. Contrary to expectations, we found significant and positive three-way interactions among source type, authority-based strategy, and machine heuristic beliefs in both social (human: $B = -0.79$, $SE = 0.23$, $p < .001$; hybrid: $B = -0.75$, $SE = 0.25$, $p = .003$) and scientific topics (human: $B = -0.41$, $SE = 0.19$, $p = .036$; hybrid: $B = -0.44$, $SE = 0.22$, $p = .049$). Simple slopes ([Figures 2–3](#)) showed that individuals with high machine heuristic beliefs rated AI's authority-based strategy as equally credible as

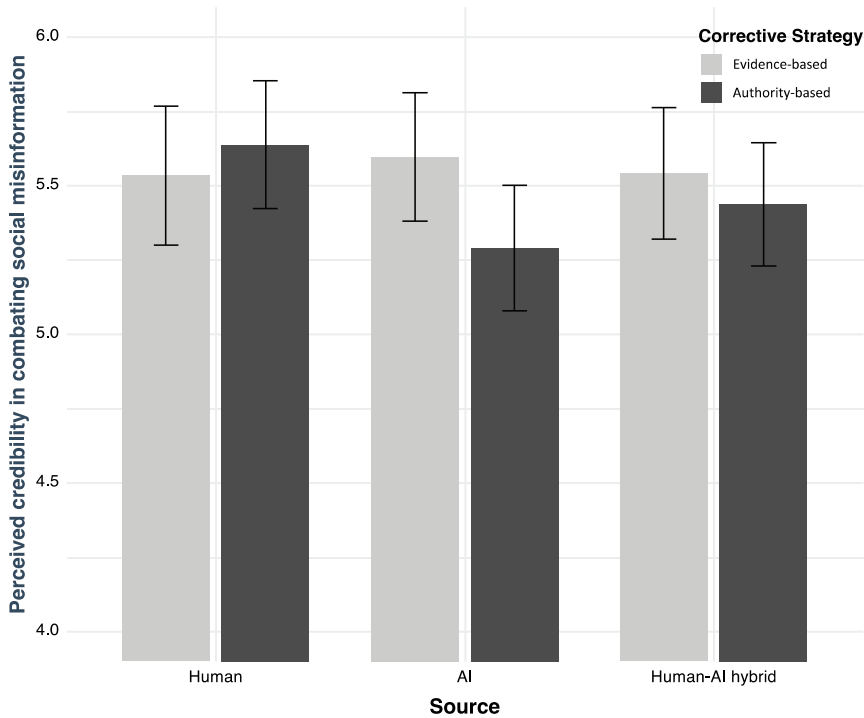


Figure 1. Two-way interaction between source and corrective strategy.

human or hybrid sources, whereas low-belief individuals rated AI as least credible. This result contradicts H3 that machine heuristic beliefs make the AI's authority-based strategy less credible by negatively violating expectancy. Hence, H3 was rejected.

H4 and RQ3 examine the moderating effect of authoritarian personality. The interaction effect between authority-based strategy and authoritarian personality was not significant in either topic. Only one three-way interaction among authoritarian personality, strategy and hybrid source, was significant in scientific correction ($B = 0.28$, $SE = 0.13$, $p = .03$). The simple slope test suggested that people with higher level of authoritarian personality consider both corrective strategies similarly credible under a human-AI hybrid source ($B = -0.05$, $SE = 0.19$, $p = .79$), but individuals with a low authoritarian personality tend to trust the evidence-based strategy ($B = -0.78$, $SE = 0.21$, $p < .001$), as Figure 4 shows. Therefore, H4 was not supported and RQ3 was answered.

Finally, we estimated a combined model including topic $\times$ all predictor interactions to test whether effects differed between science and social conditions. The results showed that only the interaction between topic and corrective strategy reached significance ($B = 2.54$, $SE = 1.24$, $p = .04$), indicating that the main effect of strategy differs across topics. All other topic-related interaction terms were non-significant, suggesting that the overall pattern of effects was largely consistent between the science and social misinformation conditions, answering RQ4.



Figure 2. Three-way interaction effect of source, corrective strategy and machine heuristic beliefs in correcting social affairs misinformation. Notes: $*p < .05$. $**p < .01$. $***p < .001$.

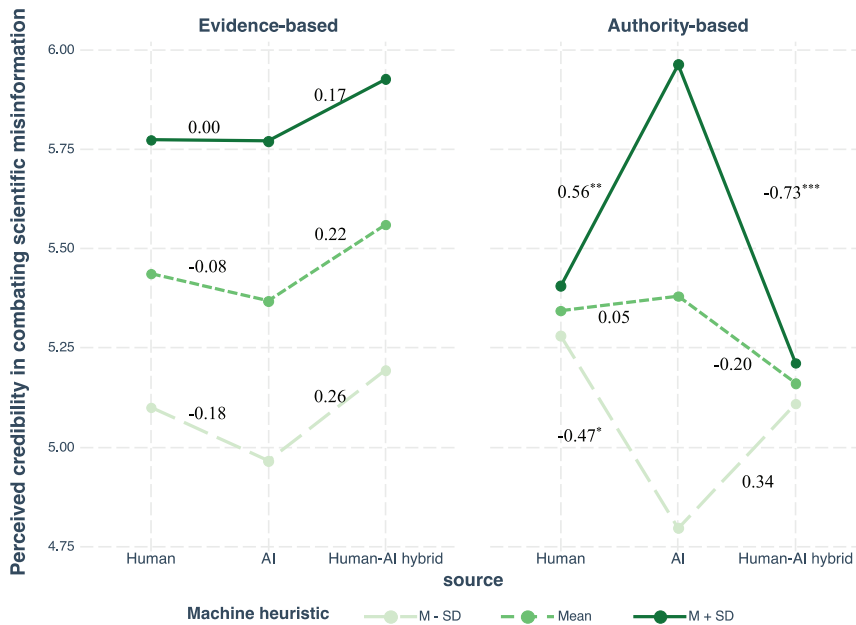


Figure 3. Three-way interaction effect of source, corrective strategy and machine heuristic beliefs in correcting scientific misinformation. Notes: $*p < .05$. $**p < .01$. $***p < .001$.



Figure 4. Three-way interaction effect of source, corrective strategy and authoritarian personality in correcting scientific misinformation. Notes: * $p < .05$. ** $p < .01$. *** $p < .001$.

Discussion

This study is one of the first attempts to assess the credibility differences between two corrective strategies, evidence-based and authority-based, in the context of AI-based misinformation correction. Drawing on machine heuristic belief and the authoritarian personality, the study explores how the effect of source and corrective strategy might fluctuate in response to varying degrees of individual characteristics.

Key Findings and Theoretical Contributions

AI authorship and corrective strategies as confounders

Our findings contribute to the debate on AI credibility by identifying the persuasive strategy as a critical confounder. Recent studies on AI credibility have produced highly contradictory results, ranging from algorithmic aversion to greater trust in AI (Chen et al., 2025; Wojcieszak et al., 2021). We demonstrate that these mixed results are likely confounded by AI's different communicative strategies across operationalizations of different studies. The lower credibility evaluation of AI appears not to be a constant, inherent reaction to the machine source itself; rather, it is specifically triggered when AI employs an authority-based strategy (Moon & Kahlor, 2025; Wang & Ophir, 2026). Thus, through disentangling AI's source effects from its persuasive strategy, this study provides a tentative theoretical lens to help reconcile the conflicting literature of AI credibility.

Effects of machine heuristic beliefs

While the machine heuristic did not moderate the main effect of the source, it significantly moderated the interaction between source and strategy. In the evidence condition, the presence of transparent data and logic serves as a strong, sufficient cue for credibility. This ceiling effect in the evidence conditions likely diluted the overall moderating power of the machine heuristic, resulting in a null main effect.

The moderating power of the machine heuristic belief acts specifically in the authoritative condition, where evidence is absent. Theoretically, the machine heuristic establishes a prescriptive expectation of objective, neutral, and data-driven traits (E.-J. Lee, 2024). According to past research and EVT, individuals with stronger machine heuristic beliefs should experience a more severe negative violation and thus assign lower credibility to the AI when the AI deviates from this expectation by employing an opaque, authoritative strategy (Tandoc et al., 2020). However, our findings did not align with this EVT prediction. Contrary to expectation, a higher level of machine heuristic belief did not lead to a harsher evaluation of the AI's authority-based strategy; on the contrary, people reported a significantly higher level of credibility for AI's authority-based strategy. As a post-hoc interpretation, this unexpected pattern implies that machine heuristic beliefs may, at higher levels, reflect unconditional trust in AI outputs, even when the communication style deviates from normative expectations of "machine-like" traits. To put it differently, the strength of machine heuristic beliefs may serve as a boundary condition under which an opaque, authoritative, persuasive strategy may be tolerated or even rewarded. However, future confirmatory research is required to rigorously test this exploratory mechanism.

Human-AI Complementarity and Authoritarian Personality as Boundaries

Prior studies on human-AI hybrid sources remain inconclusive. Theoretically, the theory of human-AI complementarity (Göndöcs et al., 2025; Jarrahi, 2018) suggests a credibility advantage, positing that collaboration integrates human sociopolitical legitimacy and contextual judgment with machine efficiency and precision (Waddell, 2019). However, our baseline results of null effects align with studies finding limited benefits. This suggests that in the context of correcting misinformation, simply applying a "human-in-the-loop" label does not automatically activate complementarity, with its credibility similar to that of human sources.

Our findings help clarify this debate by identifying authoritarian personality as a key boundary condition that alters the reception of this hybrid. Among people with a stronger authoritarian personality, we found that the decline in credibility associated with the hybrid source's authority-based strategy was no longer statistically significant. For these participants, who highly value social order, epistemic closure, and deference to established hierarchies, the hybrid agent presenting a definitive verdict may also function as a credible source, buffering the negative reaction. Given the initially weak main effects of the hybrid condition, it tentatively suggests that human-AI complementarity may not be merely a structural feature of how agents compensate for each other's functional weaknesses (e.g., AI's calculation vs. humans' social experience), but could also be contingent on the audience's cognitive habits or personalities.

Differences and similarities across topics

Contrary to our expectations (Wang & Huang, 2024), AI credibility did not differ significantly across topics. This suggests that users may view fact-checkers less as on-site reporters and more as secondary data integrators. However, given that each topic was operationalized with a single stimulus, this null effect should be interpreted cautiously and not generalized beyond the present cases. Furthermore, the authority-based strategy lowered credibility in social affairs but not in science contexts. One possible explanation is that the scientific truth is perceived as binary (Gustafson & Rice, 2020), making authoritative verdicts more tolerable as signals of expert consensus. In contrast, social affairs are more contextual; authoritative claims without evidence may elicit suspicion regarding underlying motives (Fang, 2022).

Practical Implications

Our exploratory findings offer suggestions for designing automated fact-checking systems. First, platforms (e.g., Meta, WeChat) might benefit from avoiding the design of AI that delivers authoritative but explanation-free verdicts. AI-driven interventions could consider adopting designs that provide evidence and logical reasoning by default to mitigate the credibility decrease.

Moreover, the use of hybrid sources should be approached with caution. For people with high levels of machine heuristic beliefs, adding a human element to an otherwise AI-only source actually decreased credibility in our sample. Thus, policymakers may need to limit the use of hybrid labels unless the audience is known to score high in authoritarian personality, as our data cautiously suggest.

Furthermore, it may be beneficial to dynamically adapt corrective strategies to the topics. For scientific misinformation, where expert consensus is established, authority-based strategy used by human sources may be deployed for efficiency without significant backlash (Chan & Albarracín, 2023). However, for social affairs, the authority-based strategy might exhibit a negative effect.

Limitations and Future Research

This study should be interpreted with awareness of its limitations. First, our study was conducted in China, where the digital media environment is shaped by relatively higher acceptance of institutional authority (Zhai, 2017) and widespread techno-optimism associated with state-led technological development (Wang, 2025; Xu et al., 2020). In such a context, authority-based strategy by AI or hybrid sources may be more readily interpreted as institutionally legitimate or socially appropriate, potentially attenuating negative expectancy violations. Future research should prioritize cross-cultural comparative designs to examine how variations in political culture, media institutions, and technological attitude shape the persuasive boundaries of AI in corrective communication. Also, this study focuses on nonpolitical misinformation because Chinese social media rarely allows the circulation of misinformation about domestic political events. While political misinformation is a central domain in the broader correction literature, this focus limits the direct comparability of our findings with research conducted in political fact-checking contexts.

Additionally, this study only considered a single dimension of credibility and did not take into account other dimensions, such as trustworthiness and legitimacy, leading to a limitation in conceptual granularity. This study also overlooks AI's identity cues in the real world, focusing only on fictional authorship. For instance, *ClaimBuster* uses U.S. presidential debates as a dataset and is thus effective in addressing political misinformation. The growing adoption of digital journalism calls for further investigation of real-world AI systems. More potential confounders need to be considered in future research.

Finally, three additional limitations merit acknowledgment. First, the moderating role of authoritarian personality in hybrid-source effects is acknowledged as exploratory rather than confirmatory. The observed boundary condition is contingent on our sample and specific topic context, requiring a more formally specified predictive model in future work. Second, future experiments can independently vary the degree of source transparency (e.g., how much the AI discloses its reasoning process), the stylistic assertiveness of the correction, and people's machine heuristic beliefs, to better isolate their independent contributions to credibility. Third, the finding that stronger machine heuristic beliefs predicted greater tolerance of opaque AI corrections may partly reflect confirmation bias among high-belief individuals. Future research should incorporate belief-strength measures and resistance-to-correction indices to adjudicate between these interpretations.

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